Lift the Stigma PH

Written by: Francis Louie Ramoso

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Disclaimer

This book advocates for cannabis law reform and social justice through peaceful, lawful means. It does not encourage or promote illegal activities. All claims are based on publicly available reports, historical accounts, and illustrative examples. Opinions expressed are those of the author and are intended for educational and advocacy purposes only.

Preface

This book is not just about cannabis. It's about truth, discrimination, corruption, and the voices that have been silenced for too long in the Philippines. "Lift The Stigma PH" is a movement — a message from the unheard, the criminalized, the misunderstood. My name is Francis Louie, and like many others, I've lived through judgment, fear, confusion, and the weight of a broken system. But I also believe in hope. In healing. In revolution — one led by truth.

If you're holding this book, you're already part of the fight. Let's raise our voices together.

Epigraph

"This is not just about a plant. It's about the right to heal, to rise, and to be heard." — Anonymous Filipino Voice

Dedication

To our ancestors who knew the power of plants, and to the next generation who will reclaim it. May your minds stay open, your spirits stay strong, and your healing be your revolution.

Introduction

“This is bigger than a plant.”
In the Philippines, saying the word "marijuana" out loud still gets side-eyes, whispers, or worse — handcuffs. For decades, we’ve been told it’s evil. A gateway drug. A sin. A crime.
But behind that fear is something deeper: A war not just on a plant — but on truth, healing, and freedom.
This book isn’t here to glorify cannabis. It’s here to humanize the people whose lives have been crushed, judged, or erased because of it. It’s here to ask the questions no one dares to ask:
Why is something that can heal being treated like poison?
Who benefits from keeping it illegal?
Why are the poor punished while the powerful profit?
And what does justice really look like in a country that criminalizes survival?
Cannabis has always been part of human history — including ours. Long before colonizers set foot on this land, Filipino healers already understood its power. But that story was buried. Stigmatized. Twisted by fear, foreign laws, and political control.
What you're about to read is not just a collection of facts — it's a challenge to look deeper. To question what you were taught. To listen to the voices that have been silenced. To lift the stigma — and begin a national healing.
You don’t have to be a user to care. You just have to be human. Because this is no longer just about cannabis. This is about justice, truth, and the future of the Philippines.

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✍️ Author's Note

I didn't write this book to be famous. I wrote it because I've seen too much, felt too much, and stayed silent for too long.

I've seen good people locked up, judged, or buried — not because they were criminals, but because the system was never built to understand them. I've seen mothers cry, fathers break, and youth lose their way — all while the truth was hidden behind laws, lies, and power plays.

What you'll find in these pages is truth, plain and simple. Sometimes uncomfortable. Sometimes painful. Always necessary.

This book is for those who don't have a mic. For those who were told to shut up, clean up, and disappear. For those who turned to cannabis for relief, and got a case instead of care. For every Filipino who's been told that healing is a crime.

I'm not a politician. I'm not a doctor. I'm just a voice — one of many — rising from the ground up.

And if this book can help start a conversation, shift a mindset, or plant a seed that grows into change… then every word was worth it.

The movement doesn't start in Congress or in courts. It starts with us — in the streets, in our stories, and in our hearts.

Thank you for picking this up. For reading with an open mind. And most of all, for daring to imagine something better.

— Francis Louie

2025, somewhere in the Philippines, where truth still burns bright.

Chapter 1: The Stigma

The Stigma

In the Philippines, the word "marijuana" doesn't just raise eyebrows — it **raises walls**. Walls between families. Walls between truth and lies. Walls that divide people into "good" or "bad" — just because of a plant.

Say "marijuana" in a crowded jeepney and feel the air shift. Watch eyes dart. Listen to the silence. It's not just a word — it's a **verdict**, a **sentence**, a **label**. Addict. Criminal. Lazy. Rebel. "Wala nang pag-asa 'yan." These are not facts — they are judgments. Born not out of understanding, but out of fear. And fear, when repeated enough, becomes **culture**.

But here's the truth: the fear is not ours. It was **taught** to us. Passed down like a curse from generations of colonization, corruption, and control.

The Lie We Were Sold

For decades, the Filipino people have been spoon-fed the idea that marijuana is evil. From classroom lectures to Sunday sermons, from police announcements to morning radio — the message was clear: "Masama 'yan. Iwasan mo 'yan. Makukulong ka d'yan."

But no one told us *why*. No one questioned *who* was behind this message, or what they were gaining from it.

What if the real danger wasn't the plant — but the story we've been told about it?

Personal Story: Tito Ben

Let me tell you about **Tito Ben**.

He wasn't a criminal. He wasn't an addict. He was a farmer. A father. A kind soul. After his wife died of breast cancer, he tried everything to manage his own stress and chronic pain. The meds the doctor gave made him weak, dizzy, and broke. So, like many others in the provinces, he turned to cannabis. Grew a little. Used a little.

One night, police raided his home. No warrant. No questions. Just boots, guns, and accusations. They called him a "drug personality" on TV. Neighbors stopped talking to his children. His name was destroyed in a day. He's still in jail today — for what? A handful of dried leaves.

Meanwhile, politicians in the capital steal millions with a smile.

That's not justice. That's a **war on the poor**.

Why the Fear Persists

Let's be real: **stigma is profitable**.

Media companies earn by feeding fear. Politicians score points with "tough on crime" speeches. Law enforcement fills quotas. Private jails rake in money. Pharmaceutical companies lobby to keep alternatives illegal.

And we? The people? We get silence. We get shame. We get afraid of each other.

The Language of Judgment

We need to talk about the words we use.

"Baliw."
"Adik."
"Walang kwenta."
"Sayang ka."

These words kill more dreams than drugs ever could. These are the weapons used in our homes, schools, barangays. And sometimes, we don't even realize we're passing the curse forward.

Ask yourself: Have I ever judged someone for using? Have I ever looked down on someone because of what I heard, not what I knew?

If the answer is yes, you're not alone — but now is the time to unlearn.

Stigma is Deadly

People die not because they used cannabis — they die because they were too scared to ask for help.

- Cancer patients suffer in silence, denied access to natural pain relief.
- Young boys are locked up, branded as criminals, just for experimenting.
- Breadwinners lose jobs. Kids lose parents. Families fall apart.

And yet, **none of this is happening in countries where cannabis is legal**. They moved forward. We stayed stuck — in fear, in pride, in silence.

Reflection Box 📓

"When was the first time you heard that cannabis was 'bad'? Who told you? Have you ever questioned that belief?"

Write your answers below. No shame. Just honesty.

Truth vs. System

The system that criminalizes cannabis is the same system that **protects abusers**, **jails the poor**, and **silences the brave**.

It's not a system built on truth — it's built on fear and control. And it thrives when we don't ask questions.

But this generation is waking up. We are asking. We are challenging. And we are no longer afraid to say: **The system is broken.**

Healing is Not a Crime

I've seen mothers hiding the truth from their children. I've seen sick people choosing pain over prison. I've seen families crumble because they were too scared to tell their neighbors the truth.

But I've also seen **hope**.

I've seen people heal. I've seen stories shift. I've seen youth speak up. And I've seen that when the stigma is lifted — even just a little — people breathe easier.

Because cannabis is not the enemy.

The enemy is **ignorance**.
The enemy is **greed**.
The enemy is **shame**.

And the only cure is **truth**.

Call to Arms 🚨

This chapter is your wake-up call. Your reminder. Your challenge.

Do not let fear rule your beliefs. Do not let lies define your truth. Question everything. Speak up. Listen. And most of all — **fight for those who can't**.

Because lifting the stigma isn't just about weed.

It's about **justice**.
It's about **freedom**.
It's about **compassion**.
It's about **us**.

Let's lift it — together. 💚
One story at a time. One truth at a time. One chapter at a time.